

“OPEN SOURCE ALLOWED ME TO SWIM FREELY AND SHAPE MY JOURNEY”



In spite of not being a developer or having any technical background, his emails used to be answered by renowned computer scientists and founders of open source projects. Today, he is not actively associated with open source but his contributions and efforts towards promoting open source are truly commendable. Busy with another passion of his, motorsports, **Sudev Barar, director, InCarNation Sports Pvt Ltd**, remembers his professional journey as a wonderful learning experience, all thanks to open source. In a chat with **Syeda Beenish, executive editor of OSFY**, he talks about the market challenges way back in the 1990s and how open source helped his organisation to do more with fewer investments. The excerpts...

The first encounter

Being a commerce graduate from Punjab University, my open source journey has two aspects – how it impacted me, as a person, and how it affected my enterprise. I adopted open source to benefit from the

technology, but more than that, there was a lot of learning. Not being a software developer or a programmer, even downloading Linux onto the desktop computer was a challenge for me way back in the late 90s.

Though I was not an IT person, yet, by default, I was taking care of this aspect for the company I was part of. Back in those days, companies made a lot of promises about what a particular technology could do for enterprises, but practically, they were unable to take the enterprise load.

Since I love reading, I discovered Linux around 1992-93. My sheer curiosity and my business' needs got me hooked to open source. And since 1997, I have been actively involved with it.

The journey

I first got personally interested in Linux and then I realised it could be a perfect fit for my organisation's needs. My team supported me, and I could show the management huge savings in terms of money and enhanced performance if we used open source.

I was part of a company called Nuchem Limited, with about 1200 employees, of which around 150 were office staff. They needed to communicate internally and externally. We were using computers and the first choice for the operating system had been Windows, but there was a licence fee associated with it. Licensing was a costly affair and best avoided. It's not that we did not buy licences at all—we did have licensed versions of CAD because it was absolutely necessary for our work.

Using pirated software would have saved costs, but we never wanted to go that way. I had a team of four people under me. We all had interesting learning paths and delivered big results within small budgets.

We faced challenges but found innovative answers. For example, David